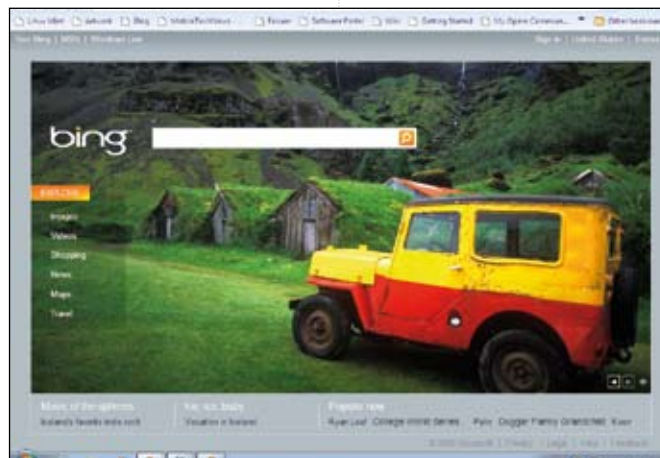


Search Engine Galore

Yes, Bing, Microsoft's revamped search engine, has launched to much hype. We got all sorts of reports from early adopters ranging from "meh" to "it's okay" to "it's good and I'm making it my default search engine". While we're all for change, should we really be switching to something sub-optimal just for the sake of change? Probably not. But is Bing sub-optimal? Let's look at what the search engine offers. Like Google, it's fast, it has image search, news search integration – which for local news is better than Google News – and your regular maps, videos and products search. It even offers auto suggestions as you type your query. However, in spite of all the glitter, a search engine is only as good as the results it's able to deliver, right?

To be able to look at this objectively we need to first analyse what the various search scenarios for most of us normally are. At times we're looking for some yes or no (factual) type of information. For instance, if you were to type Digit Magazine, you're probably expecting a search engine to take you to our web site. There is nothing better or worse than a search engine can provide other than a link to the thinkdigit web site and maybe a Wikipedia entry. But what about a search where you don't really know what you're looking for. In this case, your knowledge of a particular subject will be restricted to the search engine results. This brings in the question of trust. Here is probably where Bing stands to lose out to Google. When it comes to such searches, users will constantly find themselves cross checking with the search giant to see if the older more experienced search engine gives them better results. There is always the underlying doubt – "Am I missing out on



something. Will Google be able to show me something else?"

Let's put it through a small test. First to level the playing field, we change the location of Bing to United States. This is because the search engine has become notorious for geography based content filtering. There is no way to turn the censor off except to change your default location. Bing definitely loses a few points here. Next we threw a set of search terms at both the contenders. The terms include a deliberately misspelled word (yes many folks use search engines as spell checkers), a single answer query like "Population of India", and a more research oriented search term such as "server virtualization". In the first query both search engines perform equally well. So we kept entering many more misspelled words. Google proved better at its "did you mean?" suggestions. For "Population of India" the results were quite curious. Google returned 1,147,995,904 while Bing showed 1,147,995,900 – from different sources! Next comes the more open ended test. Both performed quite well, returning almost identical results. Except Bing showed three sponsored results eating up valuable screen space. Google had a few news results too, which Bing did not

in the main results page. Bing, however, has a nice little feature that lets you expand the snippet text by moving the mouse over to the side of the search result.

This little back of the envelope test is of course not perfect but it is indicative. Even if Bing is just as good as the currently reigning search champion, will we trust it enough to be exhaustive and accurate? Most likely, we'll keep benchmarking it against Google for days to come. Are the breathtaking backdrops with tidbits of interesting click-able information enough to make it the search engine of choice? Some folks might switch, enamoured by the novelty and buzz. But most will keep coming back to Google at least for now. Until of course Google does some major blunder down the line.

Wolfram|Alpha

Wolfram Alpha is not a search engine. It's a computational knowledge engine. Confused? Well, in a nutshell it is designed to simply give you answers to factual questions. For example if you were to ask it – the distance between Mumbai and Mangalore. It will not only tell you the distance as the crow flies, but also by road, the time it will take to reach there by regular aircraft, at light speed or

even at the speed of sound. You won't even have to enter the Mangaluru form of the name. It already knows it! Sounds like the sci-fi computers we've read in so many novels right? It is exactly that – the character Data from Star Trek but not in the android form. So, in effect what Google or other search engines try to do with questions like Population of India, Wolfram will do much better. Conventional search engines will either parse language on a page and return many results, or if human intervention by way of tagging is involved, it will return information based on tagged data, or as a last alternative point you to web pages that should contain the answer. On the Wolfram web site it says its aim is to make "all systematic knowledge immediately computable by anyone". Wolfram alpha has aligned all the data it has available to it in such a way that it can actually make sense of it; compute it. It has built tiny models of computational knowledge to compute human fields of data systematically. So you can ask it to tell you anything from "Number of internet users in Asia" or how much time it will take you to type 3000 words at standard typing speed, or find out which year in history was the name John most popular and it will actually compute the answer; replete with charts, graphs and any other information you might require. Of course by now you might have guessed that it is not pre-programmed with all sets of questions and answers that can ever be asked – that's just not feasible.

Whatever little gimmicks we mentioned so far are simply wolfram being told to be a cheap conjurer of tricks, and for the world to marvel at. There is however, immense power and value in this technology. It can be used to mash up and find co-relation between stock movements, create charts and graphs to make sense of tons of socio-economic data and reveal patterns. The domains in which the engine delves into are